Asian American Digital Culture (AAAS280B)
Credit Hours: 4
Level: Undergraduate
Semester: Fall 2026
General Education: T, I, H, W

Instructor: Muhammad Waqar Azeem
Classroom Location: Nelson A Rockefeller Center | Room 259
Class Time: WF 9:45am-11:15am
Office Location: TBD
Office Hours: Tue 10:15-11:15am via zoom or in person with an appointment. zoom link.
Email: mazeem@binghamton.edu

Communication Policy:
The most efficient way to contact me is via email. I will respond to your email within 48 hours.
My email: mazeem1@binghamon.edu

Description:
This course explores the digital culture of Asian Americans and Asian immigrants in the United States. Students will learn how AI, digital platforms and technologies shape Asian American representations and identities. We will analyze online literary publications, blogs, podcasts, documentaries, and digital art projects to understand issues of racism, stereotypes, injustice, and inequalities Asian Americans experience in digital space. By the end of the course, students will be able to critically analyze digital content and appreciate its significance for Asian American communities.

Learning Outcomes:

By the end of this course, the learners will:

Critical Thinking:

1. clearly articulate an issue or problem
2. identify, analyze, and evaluate ideas, data, and arguments as they occur in their own or others' work.
3. acknowledge limitations such as perspective and bias
4. develop well-reasoned (logical) arguments to form judgments and/or draw conclusions

Information Literacy:

1. locate information effectively using tools appropriate to their need and discipline.

2. evaluate information with an awareness of authority, validity, and bias;
3. demonstrate an understanding of the ethical dimensions of information use, creation, and dissemination

Humanities:

1. demonstrate knowledge of the conventions and methods of at least one of the humanities
2. recognize and analyze nuance and complexity of meaning through critical reflection on text, visual images, or artifacts.

Writing:

1. provide considerable experience in and feedback on writing as a tool of college-level teaching and learning:

Course Requirements:

Digital Primary Texts to be Read/Watched:

Asian Americans (PBS Documentary Series) Episodes 1 (Available on BU Libraries)
Documentary: "Uploaded: The Asian American Movement" (Available here on YouTube)
Blog: "Reappropriate" by Jenn Fang
Podcast: "Self Evident: Asian America's Stories"
Digital Project: Asian American Arts Alliance
South Asian American Digital Archive (SAADA)
Online Publication: Asian American Writers' Workshop (AAWW) (Select literary texts)

Required Critical Readings:

I will upload all the critical readings in Brightspace.

Data Empire by Roopika Risam (Selections)

Asian America.Net: Ethnicity, Nationalism, and Cyberspace edited by Rachel C. Lee and Sau-ling C. Wong (Introduction)

Digitizing Race: Visual Cultures of the Internet by Lisa Nakamura (Selections)

"Political Inequality in the Digital World: The Puzzle of Asian American Political Participation" Online by N. K. Chan

"Asian America Gone Viral: A Genealogy of Asian American YouTubers and Memes" by Lori Kido Lopez (in *The Routledge Companion to Asian American Media*)

Required Material:

You will need the text of the reading/video/visual being discussed in the class. You will also need an internet-connected laptop computer as well as a notebook and a pen for all the classes.

Credit Hours and Expectations:

This course is a 4-credit course, which means that in addition to the scheduled lectures/discussions, students are expected to do at least 9.5 hours of course-related work each week during the semester. This includes things like: completing assigned readings, participating in lab sessions, studying for tests and examinations, preparing written assignments, completing internship or clinical placement requirements, and other tasks that must be completed to earn credit in the course.

Assessment:

1. Class Participation and Discussion 20%
2. Quiz 10%
3. Short Midterm Paper 20%: A 4-5 pages paper analyzing a specific component in Asian American digital culture, such as a digital art project, or literary/cultural representation in digital media.
4. Digital Content Creation 20%: Students will turn their midterm paper into a digital project, such as a podcast or a webpage.
5. Presentation 10%: Each student gives a presentation on a topic related to Asian American digital culture, followed by a Q&A session. This presentation will be based on the preliminary draft of the final paper.
6. Final paper 20%: An 8-10 pages paper analyzing a specific component in Asian American digital culture, such as a digital art project, or literary/cultural representation in digital media. This paper will also comprise a literature review of 4 academic resources. Students will use one digital text and two critical/theoretical readings to write their final paper.

Grade Scale:
A = 100-93%
A- = 92.9-90%
B+ = 89.9-87%
B = 86.9-83%

B- = 82.9-80%
C+ = 79.9-77%
C= 76.9-73%
C- = 72.9-70%
D+ = 69.9-67%
D = 66.9-63%
D- = 62.9-60%
F = 59.9% or below

General Policies:

- All students must read the required material before the class and actively participate in all class activities.
- Plagiarism may result in immediate disqualification from the course.

Mobile Phone/Laptop Policy:

Students are not allowed to use their mobile phone in class for a text message or to make/receive a phone call. They are expected to keep their phone on silent mode throughout the class. The academic use of the mobile phone is permitted only with the explicit permission/direction of the instructor. However, students can use their laptops for academic purposes as and when needed.

Absences Due to Religious Holidays:

If you anticipate being absent because of any religious observance, please notify me in writing at least one week in advance. We will work together to compensate for the missed work, discussion and assignments.

Attendance & Participation:

Attendance is required in all classes. You can be excused from a maximum of 4 classes in the semester without any penalty. After that, each absence (beyond 4th) will result in a drop of one letter grade. For example, with 5 absences, your grade will drop from A to A-. There is no make-up for the missed classes because class participation and discussion are essential for this course. You will be rewarded with a perfect score in Class Participation as long as you meet the attendance requirements and actively contribute to the class discussion during recitations and lectures. Students who repeatedly arrive late to the lecture/class will have their Class Participation grade lowered. To be considered on time, you should be seated in the classroom at the class start time.

Class participation is a very important part of the learning process in this course. You will be evaluated on the QUALITY of your contributions and insights. Quality comments possess one or more of the following properties:

- Offers a different and unique, but relevant, perspective;
- Contributes to moving the discussion and analysis forward;
- Builds on other comments;
- Transcends the "I feel" syndrome. That is, it includes some evidence, argumentation, or recognition of inherent tradeoffs. In other words, the comment demonstrates some reflective thinking.

While your participation grade is subjective, it will not be random or arbitrary. And, clearly, more frequent quality comments are better than less frequent quality comments.

You are also required to meet the instructor outside the class hours (zoom or in person per your choice) to discuss your short midterm paper topic and thesis. This meeting will earn you 1 point towards your class participation.

Academic Integrity:
Unless specified otherwise in the syllabus, I expect the work you submit for grading to be yours and yours alone. Not acknowledging another's work with proper references, taking credit for someone else's work, letting your work appear in another student's paper, or fabricating "results" are grounds for failing the assignment and/or the course. If you have any questions about what constitutes plagiarism or cheating, please ask me.

Use of Generative AI:

The use of generative AI tools or apps for assignments in this course, including tools like ChatGPT and other AI writing or coding assistants, is prohibited. (Policies below are copied from Binghamton University Website)

- The knowing use of generative AI tools, including ChatGPT and other AI writing and coding assistants, for the completion of, or to support the completion of, an examination, term test, assignment, or any other form of academic assessment, may be considered an academic offense in this course.
- Representing as one's own an idea, or expression of an idea, that was AI-generated may be considered an academic offense in this course.
- Students may not copy or paraphrase from any generative artificial intelligence applications, including ChatGPT and other AI writing and coding assistants, for the purpose of completing assignments in this course.
- The use of generative artificial intelligence tools and apps is strictly prohibited in all course assignments unless explicitly stated otherwise by the instructor in this course. This includes ChatGPT and other AI writing and coding assistants. Use of generative AI in this course may be considered use of an unauthorized aid, which is a form of cheating.

- This course policy is designed to promote your learning and intellectual development and to help you reach course learning outcomes.

Disability-Related Equal Access Accommodations Statement:
Students wishing to request academic accommodations to ensure their equitable access and participation in this course should notify the instructor as soon as they are aware of their need for such arrangements. Authorizations from Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) are required. We encourage you to contact SSD at (607) 777-2686 to schedule an appointment with the Director or Learning Disabilities Specialist. The SSD website (www.binghamton.edu/ssd/) includes information regarding their Disability Documentation Guidelines. The office is located in UU–119.

Schedule

Session	Day/date	Holiday	Reading	Activity	Assignment Due
1	Wed 8/19		Icebreaker	Discussion	
2	Fri 8/21		Syllabus	Discussion	
3	Wed 8/26		Asian Americans PBS Documentary Ep 1	Discussion	
4	Fri 8/28		Asian Americans PBS Documentary Ep 1	Discussion	
5	Wed 9/2		Lee & Wong	Discussion	
6	Fri 9/4		Documentary : Uploaded	Discussion	
7	Wed 9/9		Documentary : Uploaded	Discussion	
	Fri 9/11	No classes (Rosh Hashanah)	No classes (Rosh Hashanah)	No classes (Rosh Hashanah)	
8	Wed 9/16		Nakamura, Lisa	Discussion	

9	Fri 9/18		"Reappropriate" by Jenn Fang	Discussion	Quiz
10	Wed 9/23		"Reappropriate" by Jenn Fang	Discussion	
11	Fri 9/25		Chan, N. K.	Discussion	
12	Wed 9/30		Chan, N. K.	Discussion	
13	Fri 10/2		"Self Evident: Asian America's Stories"	Discussion	
14	Wed 10/7		"Self Evident: Asian America's Stories"	Discussion	Short Midterm Paper
15	Fri 10/9		Asian American Arts Alliance	Discussion	
	10/10-10/18	No classes (Fall break)	No classes (Fall break)	No classes (Fall break)	No classes (Fall break)
16	Wed 10/21		Asian American Arts Alliance	Discussion	
17	Fri 10/23		Asian American Arts Alliance	Discussion	
18	Wed 10/28		SAADA	Discussion	
19	Fri 10/30		Lopez, Lori Kido	Discussion	
20	Wed 11/4		AAWW: Poetry	Discussion	
21	Fri 11/6		Risam, Roopika	Discussion	Digital Content Creation
22	Wed 11/11			Presentations	
23	Fri 11/13			Presentations	

24	Wed 11/18			Presentations	
25	Fri 11/20			Presentations	
	11/25-11/29	No classes (Thanksgiving break)	No classes (Thanksgiving break)	No classes (Thanksgiving break)	
26	Wed 12/2		Final Paper Draft Review	Discussion	
27	Fri 12/4	Last Class	Final Paper Draft Review	Discussion	**Final Paper Due on Dec 10**